The 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee

By Rachel Sheinkin, William Finn and Rebecca Feldman

Suggested Roles:
ACTRESS: *Rona, A Speller, Olive, Schwarzy, Audience Speller #1, Chip*
ACTOR: *Coneybear, Panch, Barfee,*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

CONEYBEAR: **(Pg 11-12)** *(Phone rings . . . Leaf Coneybear answers)* Hello, Leaf speaking. *(with growing excitement)* Uh, huh. Uh, huh, Uh, huh! Wow! *(puts hand over receiver and yells to his family)* Mom! Dad! Marigold, Brook, Pinecone, Raisin, Landscape, Paul – you're not going to believe this! I made the county finals in the spelling bee!

******Scene******

RONA: [Welcome to the] **(Pg 5)** 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee **(Pg 7)** Hello, I'm Rona Lisa Peretti, and I'm pleased to be your host. Unfortunately, our usual word pronouncer, Superintendent Spriggs has *[fallen ill]*,* so please join me in welcoming back Vice Principal Douglas Panch.

**[Ad lib note: "fallen ill" can be replaced with a topical or local reference, ex: "Is quarantined with COVID-19 like symptoms]*

PANCH: **(Pg 8)** *(clearly infatuated with Rona)* Thank you, Rona, and I would like to say as to the incident 5 years ago, I'm in a much better place now.

RONA: And now for the official spelling bee rules.

PANCH: **(Pg 9-10)** A speller may ask questions about the word's pronunciation or definition, and use in a sentence. If you start to spell a word, you may start over,

PANCH AND A SPELLER: but the sequences of letters already spoken may not be changed.

RONA: If you misspell a word, we will ring the bell. *(Ding)* and the comfort counselor will escort you off stage!

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PANCH: So, is that understood spellers?

OLIVE AND BARFEE: Yes

OLIVE: **(Pg 7)** What school do you go to?

BARFEE: Shut up!

PANCH: **(Pg 10)** Then, without further ado, let the spelling begin.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *The 25th Annual Putnam County Spelling Bee*
ACTOR: *by Rachel Sheinkin, William Finn and Rebecca Feldman*

PANCH: **(Pg 10-11)** Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre . . .

RONA: Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre is the head of the Gay-Straight Alliance at her elementary school!

PANCH: STRABISMUS

SCHWARZY: *(with a pronounced lisp and other facial and body tics)* Strabismus. May I please have the definition of that word?

PANCH: "The inability of one eye to obtain binocular vision with the other because of an imbalance of the muscles of the eyeball."

SCHWARZY: And use in a sentence please?

PANCH: "In the schoolyard Billy protested that he wasn't cockeyed. 'I suffer from strabismus,' he said, whereupon the bullies beat him harder.

SCHWARZY: Strabismus. S-T-R-A-B-I-S-M-U-S. Strabismus.

PANCH: That is correct . . . Mr. Coneybear.

RONA: Mr. Coneybear **(Pg 18)** is recovering from headlice.

PANCH: **(Pg 12-13)** CAPYBARA

CONEYBEAR: What? Is that a word? What does it mean?

PANCH: "A tailless largely aquatic South American rodent often exceeding four feet in length"

CONEYBEAR: Oh . . . can you use it in a sentence?

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PANCH: Yes. "Don't look now, Pedro, but I think that tailless, largely aquatic four-and-a-half foot rodent swimming next to you may be a capybara."

CONEYBEAR: Wow, that didn't help at all! C-A-P-Y-B-A-R-A. Capybara.

PANCH: This is correct. . . Miss Ostrovsky.

RONA: Miss Ostrovsky came in second in her school's Halloween contest.

OLIVE: I was road-kill!

PANCH: *(Selected from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2 and instructions on page 16)* APOOP

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: **(Pg 11)** Can I have a definition

PANCH: *(from Appendix #2, Pg 85)* "Toward the back; to move astern on a boat"

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: Could you use it in a sentence?

PANCH: *(from Appendix #2, Pg 85)* "Guido, the seasick Italian sailor said, 'Scusa me, boys, but I'm-a-gonna go apoop."

AUDIENCE SPELLER 1: Apoop. A-P-O-O-P. Apoop.

PANCH: **(Pg 19-21)** That is correct . . . Mr. Tolentino

RONA: Charlito "Chip" Tolentino is a little league pitcher with a wicked 22-mile an hour screwball!

PANCH: OMPHALOSKEPSIS

CHIP: Wait a second, didn't the [last girl] just get APOOP?

PANCH: Yes, and you got: Omphaloskepsis.

CHIP: Can that also be pronounced "omPHAloskepsis"?

PANCH: It can . . . . It would be WRONG.

CHIP: Omphaloskepesis. O . . M . . . P . . . H. . . A . . L-O-S-K-E-P-S-I-S. Omphaloskepsis.

PANCH: That is correct.

RONA: He rallies and nails it. That's what it means to be a champion!

PANCH: Mr. Coneybear . . . **(Pg 23)** CRAYON . . . That's correct.

CHIP: Come on!

SCHWARZY: *(Off stage)* Damn it!

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PANCH: **(Pg 17)** Mr. Barfee

BARFEE: It's Barfee

RONA: **(Pg 33)** Mr. Barfee made it to the finals last year, but had to be eliminated for health related reasons.

BARFEE: *(momentary flashback, a horrified BARFEE in the midst of an allergic reaction)* Were there peanuts in the brownies? Cause they said there wouldn't be no peanuts in the brownies!

PANCH: **(Pg 17-18)** LUGUBRIOUS

BARFEE: One moment please.

RONA: Okay watch this technique – He calls it the Magic Foot, and he's the only one I've ever seen use it. *(Barfee enacts)* He spells it out on the floor so he can get a visual an then speaks it outloud.

BARFEE: Lugubrious. L-U-G-U – Lugu! B-R-I-O-U-S – Lugubrious.

RONA: Incredible!

BARFEE: I know.

PANCH: **(Pg 10)** Miss Schwartzandgrubenierre . . . *(Selected from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2 and instructions on page 16)* DENGUE

SCHWARZY: *(attempts a couple of pronunciations)* DENGUE? DENGUE? May I please have the definition of that word?

PANCH: *(from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2, Pg 88)* "A disease transmitted by mosquitoes that causes headache and severe diarrhea.

SCHWARZY: And use in a sentence please?

PANCH: *(from Audience Volunteer Words – Appendix #2, Pg 88)* When the pediatrician asked Billy to describe the symptoms of his dengue, he said, "It's like there was a race out of my Tushy and everybody won."

SCHWARZY: D-E-N-G-U-E. Dengue

PANCH: That is correct. . . Mr. Tolentino . . .

RONA: Chip **(Pg 53)** has a sea anemone circus in his basement!

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CHIP: **(Pg 32)** *(distracted by a beautiful girl)* Leaf . . . that girl in the second row in the fuzzy sweater? Is that your sister? **(Pg 36)** Marigold . . . Marigold Coneybear . . .

PANCH: Mr. Tolentino . . .

CHIP: *(caught up in his fantasy)* Sorry- Um . . . can you maybe skip me and ask me two later?

PANCH: Why would you want to do that?

CHIP: I'd rather not say? *(awkwardly covering his zipper region)*

PANCH: **(Pg 37-38)** You can either take your turn now or forfeit.

CHIP: I'll take my turn now

PANCH: TITTUP. The word is TITTUP.

CHIP: *(Chip giggles, then squelches it)* Definition please

PANCH: It means "lively movement or behavior. It refers to the sound of horse's hooves – tittup, tittup, tittup. *(he demonstrates a little gallop while he repeats the words)*

CHIP: Tittup. T . . I . . T *(winks and points at Marigold in the audience)* U – Oh wait. Two T's. Backing up, T-I-T-T-U-P. Tittup. *(Ding)*

PANCH: I'm sorry. The correct spelling is T-I-T-T-U-P. If you start to spell a word you may start over . . .

RONA and PANCH: but the sequences of letters already spoken may not be changed.

CHIP: That's not fair. It got it right. I can't get out on a word I spelled right. I won last year!!!

BARFEE: **(Pg 44-45)** *(Jeering)* See you next year! *(Chip makes a motion toward him)* You could be disqualified for that – if you hadn't already been eliminated!

CHIP: You know something, Barf: I may have lost, but you are the biggest loser here! *(stomps off)*

BARFEE: Oh yeah? Well, that is a common misperception

OLIVE: Sorry about that – William, right? I'm Olive.

BARFEE: I know your name. Look, I do not need pity from a person named after a vegetable.

OLIVE: It's a fruit.

BARFEE: Well, it's a disgusting fruit! *(hurt, she begins to walk away)* I guess it's okay for a name though.

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OLIVE: Did you know that if you switch the first two vowels in "Olive" it becomes "I love"?

BARFEE: Did you know that if you switch the first two vowels in "William" it becomes . . . "William"?

OLIVE: Oh . . . Well, you're a really great speller.

BARFEE: Yeah? Thanks! *(Olive exits)* "Olive." "I love." – That's so . . . *(makes an exasperated sound)*

RONA: **(Pg 45-46)** Ladies and gentlemen . . . Our final spellers! Leaf Coneybear, Mr. William Barfee, Miss Olive Ostrovsky and Miss Logainne Schwartzandgrubenierre.

SCHWARZY: I'd like to take one moment to thank my two fathers who've been so supportive of me. Thank you, dads!!

PANCH: **(Pg 49)** Please spell INDICANT

SCHWARZY: Indicant. I-N-D-I-C-A-N-T

BARFEE: P-A-L-A-V-E-R

OLIVE: H-A-L-L-U-X

PANCH: **(Pg 27-28)** ACOUCHI

CONEYBEAR: A-what? *(beat)* At a spelling bee?! What's it mean?

PANCH: "A South American rodent of the genus Myoprocta, resembling an agouti"

CONEYBEAR: It's funny how I keep getting South American rodents.

PANCH: *(Deadpan)* Hilarious.

CONEYBEAR: **(Pg 29)** A-C-O-U-C-H-I. Acouchi.

PANCH: That is correct.

SCHWARZY: **(Pg 51-53)** *(Rapid pace)* Part of speech **PANCH:** That is correct.

OLIVE: From the tupi? **BARFEE:** Yes, of course. **RONA:** That is correct.

PANCH: That is correct. **RONA:** That is correct. **PANCH:** I'm sorry, that is incorrect.

CONEYBEAR: *(Gasps!)* It is? *(deflated he exits)* Apple juice please!

PANCH: **(Pg 67)** Miss Schwarzandgrubeniere. Vug

SCHWARZY: Vug? That's the whole word?

PANCH: Vug.

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SCHWARZY: Vug. V-U-G-G-H-E. Vugghe. (Ding)

PANCH: I'm sorry, the correct answer is V-U-G. Vug

SCHWARZY: *(near tears)* So simple? *(she exits)*

RONA: **(Pg 68)** How exciting! Will the final two spellers please step forward. *(Olive and Barfee step forward)*

PANCH: **(Pg 71-72)** Miss Ostrovsky – Elanguescence.

OLIVE: Elanguescence . . . *(Olive freezes)*

BARFEE: Hey Olive, don't think I'm distracted by your eyes and your smile and your hairdo . . .

OLIVE: *(looking at Barfee, she misses on purpose)* E-L-A-N-G-U-E-S-S-E-N-C-E *(Ding)*

PANCH: That's incorrect.

RONA: No speller can win on another's speller's mistake. Mr. Barfee must spell the next word correctly to take the Putnam Bee!

PANCH: William. Spell Weltanschauung.

BARFEE: Of course, Weltanschauung. *(doing his foot spelling technique)* W-E-L-T-A-N-S-C-H-A- *(He freezes)*

OLIVE: **(Pg 73-74)** Mama, I made a friend. I am fine with second.

BARFEE: S-C-H-A-U *(he looks over at Olive)*

OLIVE: It's okay, Barf.

BARFEE: U-N-G Weltanschauung

PANCH: We have a winner! **(Pg 75)** On behalf of our sponsors, we'd like to present you with this two-hundred-dollar savings bond toward your future education.

BARFEE: All my life I have only been able to breathe through one nostril and today is NOT an exception!

OLIVE: **(Pg 76)** Congratulations!!!

BARFEE: *(said with affection)* Shut up!

****** Epilogues******

PANCH: **(Pg 76-78)** Vice Principal Panch found a new passion in life -- Rona Lisa Peretti. After courting her tirelessly for over two years, she took out a restraining order on him.

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RONA: Rona Lisa Perretti left Putnam County and traveled the world to bring competitive spelling to the less fortunate. She fell in love with an indigenous cashew farmer . . .

CHIP: Chip Tolentino made it through adolescence!

CONEYBEAR: Leaf Coneybear has cats!

SCHWARZY: Logainne Schwartzandgrubenierre won the 31st annual Putnam County Spelling Bee. She went on to become Secretary of Education under President [insert president's name here] *(dropping her lisp)* Her speech therapy was successful!

BARFEE: William Morris Barfee grew up to be incredibly handsome!

OLIVE: Olive Ostrovsky grew up to be the host of her own radio talk show, where every year she interviewed the runner-up of the Putnam County Spelling Bee.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
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2019 National Qualifier
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